

A Step-by-Step Guide to Unlocking Your iPhone, iPad, or iPod Touch

Quickly regain access to a locked iOS device

Written by Megaera Lorenz, PhD

Last Updated: January 22, 2025 Fact Checked

[Unlocking from the Lockout Screen](#) | [Resetting with a Computer](#) | [Resetting with iCloud](#) | [Unlocking with a Known Passcode](#) | [Unlocking with Face ID](#) | [Unlocking with Touch ID](#) | [Video](#) | [Show more](#)

This wikiHow teaches you how to unlock an iPhone, iPad, or iPod Touch in a variety of different situations. These situations include resetting a password-protected device to which you don't have access, as well as unlocking a device to which you know the password. We'll also teach you how to set up and use Face ID or Touch ID to unlock your iPhone or iPad.

What to Know About Unlocking an iOS Device

If you've forgotten your passcode, you can unlock an iPhone or iPad running iOS 15.2 or later from the security lockout screen. Just tap **Forgot Password?** or **Erase [Device]** and follow the prompts to reset your device. If you're running an older OS or have an iPod Touch, use a computer to unlock your device.

Method

1

Unlocking from the Lockout Screen

- 1 Enter your passcode incorrectly a few times.** After a few attempts, you'll see a "[Device] Unavailable" screen.^[1]
 - This will only work if you're using an iPhone or iPad running iOS/iPadOS 15.2 or later. If you're trying to unlock an iPod touch or a device with an older OS, you'll need to use a computer.
 - You'll also need to be connected to either Wi-Fi or a cellular network to reset your device this way.
 - If you're using an iPhone with an eSIM running iOS 16 or earlier, contact your carrier before you start and ask them for a QR code to set up your eSIM again.

- 2 Tap "Forgot Password?"** After a few incorrect password attempts, this

2 Tap **Forgot Password?** After a few incorrect password attempts, this message will appear in the bottom right corner of the screen.

- In iOS/iPadOS 16 or earlier, tap **Erase [Device]** instead.

Advertisement

3 Select **Start [Device] Reset**. This will confirm your selection and begin the reset process.

4 Enter your Apple Account password. This will sign you out of your device. If you don't remember your Apple Account password, you'll need to reset it before you can use this method.

5 Select **Erase Device**. If you're using iOS 17 or later and you have an eSIM, you'll be offered the option to either keep or erase your eSIM when you erase your other data.

6 Follow the prompts to set up your device again. Once your iPhone or iPad finishes resetting, it will restart and prompt you to set it up again. If you have a backup, you'll have an opportunity to use it now. You can also set a new passcode for your device.

7 Use Passcode Reset if you recently changed your passcode. If you just changed your passcode and then forgot the new one, you can temporarily log in with your old passcode in iOS 17 or later. This option will only last for 72 hours after you change your passcode.

- Enter your passcode incorrectly a few times until you see the lockout screen.
- Tap **Forgot Passcode?**
- Select **Try Passcode Reset** or **Enter Previous Passcode** and enter your old passcode.
- Follow the prompts to set a new passcode.

Advertisement

Method 2

Resetting with a Computer

1 Turn off your device. If you can't reset your locked device from the security lockout screen, you can do so from a Mac or PC. You'll need to put your device in recovery mode and erase it. If you have a backup, you can use that to restore your device after you erase it. To get started, disconnect your iPhone, iPad, or iPod touch from its charger and any other accessories and turn it off.

- The right way to shut down an iPhone or iPad depends on the model.
- To turn off your iPod touch, press and hold the top button until you see the power slider, then swipe the slider to turn your iPod off.^[2]

2 Put your device in recovery mode. The way you do this varies slightly

2 Put your device in recovery mode the way you do this varies slightly depending on your device.

- **iPhone:**^[3]

- Connect your phone to your computer with a USB cable (if you have a Mac with USB-C ports, you may need to use an adapter). As soon as you plug in your phone, press and hold the side button. If you have an iPhone 7 or 7 Plus, use the Volume Down button instead. On an iPhone 6s or earlier, use the Home button.
- Keep holding the side button on your iPhone as it starts up until you see an image of a computer and a cable.

- **iPad:**^[4]

- Connect your iPad to your computer with a USB cable. You might need an adapter if you have a newer Mac with USB-C ports.
- If your iPad has no Home button, press and release the volume button closest to the top button, then press and hold the top button.
- If your iPad has a Home button, press and hold that and the top or side button at the same time.
- Keep holding the button(s) until you see an icon of a computer and a cable on your screen.

- **iPod touch:**

- If you have an iPod Touch 7th generation, press and hold the Volume Down button. For a 6th generation, press and hold the Home button.
- Immediately after pressing the button, plug your iPod touch into your computer.
- Keep holding the button until you see an icon of a computer screen on your iPod.

3 Open Finder or iTunes on your computer. If you're using a Mac running macOS Catalina or later, open a Finder window. For a Mac running Mojave or earlier, or a PC, open iTunes.

- Finder or iTunes may launch automatically when you connect your device in recovery mode.
- You can also use the Apple Devices app on a Windows PC.

4 Open your device in Finder or iTunes. You should see an icon of your device in the sidebar of Finder or the top bar of iTunes. Click on it to open your iPhone, iPad, or iPod touch.

5 Click . A window will pop up asking if you want to update or restore your device. Select the **Restore** option.

- You may be prompted to trust the device before you can continue.
- In Apple Devices on a PC, you may need to select your device, then go to **General > Restore [device]** or **Restore Backup** (if you have a backup on your computer).^[5]

- In iTunes, select the device, then click **Summary > Restore [device]** and select the option to Restore.
- Your device may need to update before it can finish resetting. This may take around 15 minutes.

6 Follow the prompts to set up your device again. Once the reset process is complete, you'll see a "Hello" screen on your iPhone, iPad, or iPod. Follow the prompts to set up your device, restore it from a backup (if you have one), and set a new passcode.

Advertisement

**Method
3**

Resetting with iCloud

1 Open the Find Devices webpage. iCloud's Find My service allows you to erase your iPhone, iPad, or iPod touch without having access to the device itself. This is also a good option if you can't use a computer to reset your device, or you can't reset from the lock screen. To get started, go to <https://www.icloud.com/find> on a computer or in a mobile browser.

- This option will only work if Find My was already enabled on your device before you forgot your passcode.^[6]

2 Click Sign In and enter your Apple Account info. Click the black **Sign In** button and enter the phone number or email associated with your Apple Account, and your password. You'll need to use the same Apple Account that your locked device is signed into.

3 Click your device's name. It should say "[Your Name]'s [Device]". If you don't see it, you may need to expand the *All Devices* menu on the left side of the screen.

- For example, this option might say "Jane Doe's iPad" for an iPad.

4 Click Erase This Device. You'll see this option near the bottom of the menu for your device.

5 Click Next. Doing so will confirm your choice and take you to the password entry menu.

6 Follow the prompts to finish erasing your device. You may be prompted to enter your Apple Account ID and password. You might also see a message asking you to enter a message and contact information in case your device is lost. You can skip this step.

- Depending on whether your device is online or offline, it may be erased immediately, or the process might begin the next time your device comes

online.

- If your device isn't online, you can cancel the erase at any time. Repeat the steps above and select **Stop Erase Request** from the device menu.

7 Wait for your device to finish erasing. Once it finishes, you should see "Hello" text gliding across the screen. This is your cue to pick up your iPhone, iPad, or iPod Touch and set it back up.

- If you have a backup (e.g., in iCloud or on a computer), you can restore your device from the backup during the setup process.
- You'll also have the chance to set up a new passcode during this process.

Advertisement

**Method
4**

Unlocking with a Known Passcode

1 Press the "Lock" button to turn on the screen. An iPhone's Lock button is usually on the right side of the casing, while iPads and iPod Touches have their Lock buttons on the top of their casings.

- If you're using an iPhone 5 (or older model), the "Lock" button will be on the top of your phone's case.
- On iPhone 6S phones (and any subsequent models) with "Raise to Wake" enabled, you can simply pick up your phone to turn on the screen.

2 Swipe up from the bottom of the screen. This will take you to the passcode entry screen.

- If you're using an iPod touch or an iPhone or iPad with a Home button, press the Home button instead.

3 Type in your device's passcode. If you enter the code correctly, your device should unlock automatically.

- Passcodes come in three different configurations: 4-digit, 6-digit, and alphanumeric (numbers, letters, and symbols).

Advertisement

**Method
5**

Unlocking with Face ID

1 Check that your device supports Face ID. Face ID uses the front camera on your device to scan your face and unlock your device. With this feature, all you have to do is glance at your iPhone or iPad to unlock it! If you're not sure whether your device has Face ID, check out this list of compatible iPhones and

iPads.

- All newer iPhone models, starting with iPhone X, support Face ID.
- Most iPad Pro models support Face ID.
- The iPod touch doesn't have Face ID capability.

2 Set up Face ID in Settings. Before you can use Face ID for the first time, you'll need to do a face scan. You may have been offered this option when you first set up your device, but if not, you can do it at any time in settings.^[7]

- Open **Settings** and tap **Face ID & Passcode**.
- Enter your iPhone or iPad's passcode when prompted.
- Tap **Set up Face ID** and follow the prompts to scan your face.
- Make sure **iPhone/iPad Unlock** is toggled on under the *USE FACE ID FOR:* header. You can also toggle on any other features you'd like to use with Face ID, such as the App Store or payments.
- You can also add an alternate appearance, train Face ID to recognize you with a mask on, and even add different pairs of glasses.

3 Raise your device and look at the screen to unlock it. If your device is asleep, press the top or side button to wake it. You'll see a small padlock symbol unlock at the top of the screen as soon as your device recognizes your face.

- Swipe up from the bottom of the screen to open your Home Screen and start using your iPhone or iPad.
- If you recently updated or restarted your iPhone or iPad, you may need to enter your passcode before you can use Face ID.

Advertisement

Method
6

Unlocking with Touch ID

1 Confirm that your iOS device supports Touch ID. Note that the iPod touch does not support Touch ID. Devices that do support Touch ID include the following:

- iPhone 5S, SE, 6, 6 Plus, 6S, 6S Plus, 7, 7 Plus, 8, and 8 Plus.
- Any iPad with a Home button and models that support touch ID from the top/side button. These are iPad (10th generation), iPad Air (4th generation or later), iPad mini (6th generation), and iPad mini (A17 Pro).
- On most iOS devices, the Touch ID sensor is in the Home button. On iPad models without a Home button that support Touch ID, it's in the Lock button.

2 Set up Touch ID. If you didn't enable Touch ID when you set up your device, you can do so any time in the Settings menu.^[8]

- Go to **Settings > Touch ID & Passcode**, then enter your passcode when prompted.
- Tap **Add a Fingerprint**.
- Follow the prompts to record your fingerprint. This involves repeatedly lifting and lightly resting your preferred finger on the Touch ID sensor until it detects your entire print. You'll be asked to readjust the position of your finger several times.
 - You can record more than one fingerprint if you like.
- Toggle on **iPhone/iPad Unlock** and any other features you'd like to use with Touch ID, such as the App Store.

3 Press the "Lock" button to turn on the screen. For an iPhone, the Lock button will likely be on the right side of the casing. iPads have their Lock buttons on the top of their casings.

- The iPhone 5S and the iPhone SE are the two exceptions to this rule, wherein the Lock button is on the top of the phone's casing.

4 Rest your fingertip on the Home button. You'll need to do this with a finger you've previously registered with your iPhone or iPad.

- Make sure you're resting your finger directly on the Home button (or the Lock button, with some models of iPad).

5 Press the Home button when prompted. If your fingerprint successfully scans, you'll see the "Press home to unlock" text at the bottom of the screen. Doing so will unlock your phone.

- On models of iPad with the sensor in the Lock button, you'll be prompted to rest your finger on the button to unlock your iPad, and then the Home screen will open automatically.
- If your fingerprint doesn't adequately scan, your iOS device will transfer you to the passcode entry screen and prompt you to "Try Again."
- You may need to readjust the position of your finger on the scanner or wipe the sensor to remove dirt or grime.
- If you've recently updated or restarted your device, you'll need to log in with your passcode once before you can use Touch ID.

Advertisement

Community Q&A

Question

How do I unlock my iPod if I forgot my pass code?

Connect it up to your Mac book and wipe the whole thing. You could lose all the songs on your Ipod so be careful.

Question

How do I unlock an iPad when I put in the password and I do know the right one?

Go to the Apple store for help.

Question

What can I do if I don't remember my ID and my password for my iPad?

Contact an Apple store in your area for help recovering your information.

Advertisement

Tips

- Some iOS devices will erase all on-device data after 10 failed passcode attempts.
- If you can't get your fingerprint to scan, try wiping your hands on a dry towel/rag and trying again.

Advertisement

Warnings

- Gaining forced entry to a device that isn't yours is illegal. Do not use the information listed here to remove the password from an unowned device.

Advertisement

References

1. <https://support.apple.com/en-us/105090>
2. <https://support.apple.com/en-us/108312>
3. <https://support.apple.com/en-us/118430>
4. <https://support.apple.com/en-us/119858>
5. <https://support.apple.com/en-us/118430>
6. <https://support.apple.com/guide/ipod-touch/locate-a-device-iph09b087eda/ios>
7. <https://support.apple.com/guide/iphone/set-up-face-id-iph6d162927a/ios>
8. <https://support.apple.com/en-us/102528>

Advertisement